Obinutuzumab (Gazyvaro®)

Obinutuzumab (Gazyvaro®) is a cancer drug. It is used to treat chronic lymphocytic leukaemia (CLL) and a type of non-Hodgkin lymphoma (NHL) called follicular lymphoma (FL).

On this page

- What is obinutuzumab (Gazyvaro®)?
- How obinutuzumab is given
- About side effects
- Side effects while treatment is being given
- Very common side effects
- Other side effects
- Other important information
- How we can help

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/obinutuzumab · retrieved 19 October 2026

What is obinutuzumab (Gazyvaro®)?

Obinutuzumab is also called Gazyvaro®. It is a type of targeted therapy drug called a monoclonal antibody.

Obinutuzumab is used to treat:

- chronic lymphocytic leukaemia (CLL)
- a type of non-Hodgkin lymphoma (NHL) called follicular lymphoma (FL).

It may sometimes be used to treat other conditions.

It is best to read this information with our general information about targeted therapy drugs and the type of cancer you have.

Your cancer team will talk to you about this treatment and its possible side effects before you agree (consent) to have treatment.

More information about this treatment

This information is correct at time of publishing. But sometimes the types of cancer this treatment is used for, or treatment side effects, may change between revision dates.

You can talk to your cancer team if you want more detailed information about this treatment. Or visit the electronic Medicines Compendium (eMC) website, which has patient information leaflets (PIL) for individual drugs.

How obinutuzumab is given

You usually have obinutuzumab in a day unit or during a stay in hospital. You usually have it in combination with chemotherapy drugs.

If you have follicular lymphoma, you might continue to have obinutuzumab on its own after you have finished chemotherapy. This is called maintenance therapy. This can continue for up to 2 years. During a course of treatment, you will meet someone from your cancer team, such as a:

- blood cancer doctor (haematologist)
- specialist nurse
- specialist pharmacist.

This is who we mean when we mention doctor, nurse or pharmacist in this information.

During your course of treatment, you will have regular blood tests. This is to check that it is safe for you to have treatment.

You will meet with a doctor, nurse or pharmacist before you have treatment. They will talk to you about your blood results and ask how you have been feeling. If your blood results are okay, the pharmacy team will prepare your targeted therapy.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/obinutuzumab · retrieved 19 October 2026

You have obinutuzumab as a drip into a vein (intravenous infusion).

Your nurse will give you obinutuzumab through 1 of the following:

- a cannula – a short, thin tube the nurse puts into a vein in the arm or hand
- a central line – a fine tube that goes under the skin of the chest and into a vein close by
- a PICC line – a fine tube that is put into a vein in the arm and goes up into a vein in the chest
- an implantable port (portacath) – a disc that is put under the skin on the chest or arm and goes into a vein in the chest.

Your course of treatment

You usually have a course of several cycles of treatment over a few months. Your cancer team doctor will discuss your treatment plan with you.

About side effects

We explain the most common side effects of this treatment here. We also include some that are less common.

You may get some of the side effects we mention, but you are unlikely to get all of them. And you may have some side effects, including rarer ones, that we have not listed here.

Other cancer treatments may cause different side effects. If you are also having other cancer treatment, you may have other side effects.

Always tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist about any side effects you have. They can give you:

- drugs to help control some side effects
- advice about managing side effects.

It is important to take any drugs exactly as explained. This means they will be more likely to work for you.

Serious and life-threatening side effects

Some cancer treatments can cause serious side effects. Sometimes, these may be life-threatening. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can explain the risk of these side effects to you.

Contact the hospital

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist will give you 24-hour contact numbers for the hospital. If you feel unwell or need advice, you can call at any time of the day or night. Save these numbers in your phone or keep them somewhere safe.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/obinutuzumab · retrieved 19 October 2026

Hepatitis B reactivation

If you have ever had a liver infection called hepatitis B, obinutuzumab can sometimes make it active again. Your doctor or nurse will talk to you about this and test you for hepatitis B. You may be given treatment to reduce the risk of this happening.

Side effects while treatment is being given

Some people may have side effects while they are having this treatment or shortly after they have it.

Allergic reaction

Some people have an allergic reaction while having this treatment. The first infusion is the most likely to cause a reaction, so it is usually given more slowly than later treatments. Before treatment, you will have medicines to help prevent or reduce any reaction.

Signs of a reaction can include:

- feeling hot or flushed
- shivering
- itching
- a skin rash
- feeling dizzy or sick
- a headache
- feeling breathless or wheezy
- swelling of your face or mouth
- pain in your back, tummy or chest.

Your nurse will check you for signs of a reaction during your infusion. If you feel unwell or have any of these signs, tell them straight away. If you do have a reaction, they can treat it quickly.

Sometimes a reaction happens a few hours after treatment. If you develop any of these signs or feel unwell after you get home, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number.

Always call 999 if swelling happens suddenly or you are struggling to breathe.

Blood pressure

Your blood pressure may fall while having obinutuzumab. If you usually take medicine to lower your blood pressure, your doctor may ask you not to take it for 12 hours before having obinutuzumab.

Sometimes, obinutuzumab can make your blood pressure go up. Your nurse will check your blood pressure regularly.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/obinutuzumab · retrieved 19 October 2026

Very common side effects

These side effects happen to 10 or more people in every 100 people (10% or more) who have this treatment.

Risk of infection

This treatment can reduce the number of white blood cells in your blood. These cells fight infection. If your white blood cell count is low, you may be more likely to get an infection. A low white blood cell count is called neutropenia.

An infection can be very serious when the number of white blood cells is low. It is important to get any infection treated as soon as possible. If you have any of the following symptoms, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number:

- a temperature above 37.5°C
- a temperature below 36°C
- you feel unwell, even with a normal temperature
- you have symptoms of an infection.

Symptoms of an infection include:

- feeling shivery and shaking
- a sore throat
- a cough
- breathlessness
- diarrhoea
- needing to pass urine (pee) often, or discomfort when you pass urine.

It is important to follow any specific advice your cancer treatment team gives you.

Your white blood cell count will usually return to normal before your next treatment. You will have a blood test before having more treatment. If your white blood cell count is low, your doctor may delay your treatment for a short time, until your cell count increases.

You may be given a drug called G-CSF. This encourages the body to make more white blood cells. You have it as a small injection under the skin.

Bruising and bleeding

This treatment can reduce the number of platelets in your blood. Platelets are cells that help the blood to clot.

If the number of platelets is low, you may bruise or bleed easily. You may have:

- nosebleeds
- bleeding gums
-

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/obinutuzumab · retrieved 19 October 2026

heavy periods

- blood in your urine (pee) or stools (poo)
- tiny red, brown or purple spots that may look like a rash – these spots can be harder to see if you have black or brown skin.

If you have any unexplained bruising or bleeding, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number. You may need a drip to give you extra platelets. This is called a platelet transfusion.

Anaemia (low number of red blood cells)

This treatment can reduce the number of red blood cells in your blood. Red blood cells carry oxygen around the body. If the number of red blood cells is low, this is called anaemia. You may feel:

- very low in energy
- breathless
- dizzy and light-headed.

If you have these symptoms, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number. You may need treatment for anaemia. If you are very anaemic, you may need a drip to give you extra red blood cells. This is called a blood transfusion.

Feeling tired

Feeling tired is a common side effect of this treatment. It is often worse towards the end of treatment and for some weeks after it ends. Try to pace yourself and plan your day so you have time to rest. Gentle exercise, like short walks, can help you feel less tired.

If you feel sleepy, do not drive or use machinery.

Constipation

This treatment can cause constipation. Constipation means that you are not able to pass stools (poo) as often as you normally do. It can become difficult or painful. Here are some tips that may help:

- Drink at least 2 litres (3½ pints) of fluids each day.
- Eat high-fibre foods, such as fruit, vegetables and wholemeal bread.
- Do regular gentle exercise, like going for short walks.

If you have constipation, contact the hospital on the 24-hour number for advice. They can give you drugs called laxatives to help.

If you have not been able to pass stools for over 2 days and are being sick, contact the 24-hour number straight away.

Diarrhoea

This treatment may cause diarrhoea. Diarrhoea means passing more stools (poo) than is normal for you, or having watery or loose stools. You may also have stomach cramps. If you have a stoma, it may be more active than usual.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/obinutuzumab · retrieved 19 October 2026

If you are passing loose stools 3 or more times a day and this is not normal for you, contact the hospital as soon as possible on the 24-hour number. Follow the advice they give you about:

- taking anti-diarrhoea medicines
- drinking enough fluids to keep you hydrated and to replace lost salts and minerals
- any changes to your diet that might help.

They might also ask you for a specimen of your stool to check for infection.

Hair loss

You might notice that your hair slowly gets thinner. But you are very unlikely to lose all the hair from your head. Your hair can also become more brittle. Your nurse can give you information about coping with hair loss. Your hair will usually go back to normal after treatment ends.

Skin changes

Obinutuzumab may affect your skin and cause itching and eczema. Tell your doctor or nurse about any skin changes. They can give you advice and prescribe creams if needed. Any changes to your skin are usually temporary and improve when treatment finishes.

Muscle, joint or back pain

This treatment may cause pain in your muscles, joints or back. If this happens, tell your doctor so they can give you painkillers. Tell them if the pain does not get better.

Headaches

This treatment may cause headaches. If you have headaches, tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist. They can give you advice about painkillers that may help. Tell them if the headache does not get better, or gets worse.

Difficulty sleeping and mood changes

This treatment may cause difficulty sleeping. Some people may have depression or anxiety. If you notice these changes or any other changes to your mood, talk to your doctor or nurse.

Effects on the lungs

This treatment can cause changes to the lungs. Tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist if you develop:

- a cough that does not go away
- wheezing
- breathlessness.

You should also tell them if any existing breathing problems get worse. You may have tests to check your lungs.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/obinutuzumab · retrieved 19 October 2026

Other side effects

These side effects happen to less than 10 in 100 people (less than 10%) who have this treatment. Some of them are much rarer than this but they are still important to know about. Rare means a side effect that happens to less than 1 in 1,000 people (less than 0.1%).

Tummy pain

You may get pain in your tummy (abdomen), or have indigestion. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you advice or treatment to help. Contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number if your symptoms do not go away, or get worse.

Problems passing urine

Obinutuzumab may cause problems with passing urine (peeing). Tell your doctor or nurse straight away if you:

- have pain or difficulty peeing
- feel like you need to pee urgently and more often
- start to leak urine.

Nose irritation

This treatment may cause a blocked or runny nose. Tell your doctor or nurse if this happens. There may be medicines that may help.

High blood pressure

Obinutuzumab may cause an increase in blood pressure during treatment. Your nurse will check it regularly.

Effects on the heart

This treatment can affect how the heart works. You may have tests to check how well your heart is working. These may be done before, during and after treatment.

If the treatment is causing heart problems, your doctor may change the type of treatment you are having.

Contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number if you have any of these symptoms during or after treatment:

- breathlessness
- dizziness
- changes to your heartbeat (palpitations)
- swollen feet and ankles.

Other conditions can cause these symptoms, but it is important to get them checked by a doctor.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/obinutuzumab · retrieved 19 October 2026

Always call **999** if you have:

- chest pain, pressure, heaviness, tightness or squeezing across the chest
- difficulty breathing.

Effects on the nervous system

Rarely, this treatment can affect the nervous system. It can cause a condition called PML (progressive multifocal leukoencephalopathy). Symptoms of this include:

- difficulty speaking
- difficulty walking
- memory loss
- confusion
- changes in your eyesight.

Contact the hospital straight away if:

- you have any of these symptoms
- someone with you notices you have these symptoms.

If you notice these effects, it is important not to drive or operate machinery.

Tumour lysis syndrome (TLS)

Some people are at risk of developing a condition called tumour lysis syndrome (TLS). The risk is highest at the beginning of treatment. TLS happens when treatment makes large numbers of cancer cells die and break down quickly. This releases lots of waste products into the blood and can affect the kidneys and heart.

TLS can be prevented or treated. You will have regular blood tests to check for TLS. You may have:

- extra fluids through a drip
- medicines such as allopurinol tablets or rasburicase through a drip.

Drinking at least 2 litres (3½ pints) of fluid a day will also help.

Second cancer

Obinutuzumab can increase the risk of developing types of skin cancer called squamous cell carcinoma (SCC) and basal cell carcinoma (BCC). But the benefits of treatment usually far outweigh this risk. Your doctor can talk to you about this.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/obinutuzumab · retrieved 19 October 2026

Other important information

Blood clot risk

Cancer and some cancer treatments can increase the risk of a blood clot. Contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number if you have any of these symptoms during or after treatment:

- throbbing pain or swelling in a leg or arm
- reddening of the skin in the area – if you have black or brown skin, this can be harder to notice, but the skin might become darker
- suddenly feeling breathless or coughing.

Always call **999** if you have:

- chest pain
- difficulty breathing.

A blood clot is serious, but it can be treated with drugs called anticoagulants. These thin the blood. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you more information about preventing and treating blood clots.

Other medicines

Some medicines can affect how this treatment works or be harmful while you are having it. Always tell your cancer doctor, nurse or pharmacist about any drugs you are taking or planning to take, such as:

- medicines you have been prescribed
- medicines you buy in a shop, pharmacy or online
- vitamins or supplements
- herbal drugs and complementary or homeopathic therapies
- recreational drugs – for example, cannabis.

Vaccinations

Cancer doctors usually recommend that people with cancer have vaccinations for flu and coronavirus (covid). They may also recommend other vaccines, such as Shingrix® for shingles. These all help reduce your risk of serious illness from these infections. Most people can have these vaccines, including people with weak immune systems.

You should not have live vaccines if your immune system is weak. This includes if you are having or recently had chemotherapy, radiotherapy or other cancer treatments that affect your immune system. Live vaccines can make you unwell because they contain a very weak version of the illness they protect you against. There are several live vaccines, including the yellow fever vaccine.

It is important to ask your doctor, nurse or pharmacist for advice about having vaccinations. They can explain what vaccines are right for you and when it is best to have them.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/obinutuzumab · retrieved 19 October 2026

Contraception

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist will advise you not to get pregnant or make someone pregnant while having this treatment and for some time afterwards. The drugs may harm a developing baby. It is important to use contraception to prevent pregnancy. Follow their advice about:

- what types of contraception to use
- how long after treatment you should continue to use contraception.

Breastfeeding

You are advised not to breastfeed while having this treatment, or for some time after treatment ends. This is because the drugs could be passed to the baby through breast milk.

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you more information.

Fertility

Some cancer drugs can affect whether you can get pregnant or make someone pregnant. If you are worried about this, it is important to talk with your doctor before you start treatment.

Sex

It is possible that small amounts of chemotherapy may be passed on through vaginal fluids or semen. If you have sex in the first few days after treatment, your cancer team will usually advise using condoms or a dental dam to protect your partner.

Medical and dental treatment

If you need medical treatment for any reason other than cancer, always tell the healthcare professional that you are having cancer treatment. Give them the contact details for your cancer doctor or cancer team so they can ask for advice.

If you have appointments with a dentist, always tell them you are having cancer treatment. Talk to your cancer team before you have any dental treatment.

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References

Visit the electronic Medicines Compendium (eMC) to download a Patient Information Leaflet (PIL) for more detailed information. The leaflet lists all known side effects.

Cancer Information Development team

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/obinutuzumab · retrieved 19 October 2026

Author

Date reviewed

Reviewed: 01 July 2024 | Next review: 01 July 2026

This content is currently being reviewed. New information will be coming soon.

Our cancer information meets the PIF TICK quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about how we produce our information.

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as ‘you’ so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms ‘men’ and ‘women’ or ‘male’ and ‘female’. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information here.

How we can help

How to print a PDF from this website

Instructions on how you can make a PDF version of this page using the print function on your browser.

Clinical Information Nurse Specialists

Our Cancer Information Nurse Specialists are dedicated cancer nurses available to talk to on our Macmillan Cancer Support Line.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/obinutuzumab · retrieved 19 October 2026

Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.

Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don’t want to call.

Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.

Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

Get help

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/obinutuzumab · retrieved 19 October 2026